

Absent or Unprepared Lead Protocol

HONR 46400 · Evidence-Driven Research

(Instructor-only; not published to students.)

What to do when the scheduled Student Research Lead is absent, or arrives without a usable preparation. The goal is that the session runs well regardless, no learning block is lost, and the accountability lands fairly on the person responsible. In a seminar this small, a missed lead is rare but must never derail a class.

Naming a standby

There is no standing standby list. **When an absence is known, name a standby at random from the roster.** Drawing at random keeps it fair and keeps no one permanently on the hook. The standby is not expected to prepare in advance; they are a warm body who can run a script, and the script already exists.

If the drawn student cannot step in, draw again. If no student can step in, the instructor leads the session from the lecture notebook's **SRL Lead Brief**, which is already public to the whole class.

The prep template is the substitute's script

This is why the two-days-out template matters beyond grading. **A submitted preparation template is a complete, runnable script**, so any standby can lead from it with minutes of notice.

- Hand the standby the absent lead's template: the puzzle, the commitment question, the three Socratic questions with anticipated answers, the exact AI prompts with predicted right and wrong outputs, the assumption-probe, the counterexample request, the closing decision, and the timing plan.
- The standby runs it as written. They are not expected to improvise a new session; they are executing a colleague's plan. Grade the standby generously and separately: stepping in is a service, not their own graded slot.
- The absent lead is still accountable for the quality of the plan the standby ran, since it was their preparation.

Make-up options for the absent lead

A student who misses their slot has not lost the learning opportunity, only the scheduled one. Offer, in order of preference:

1. **Swap with another student's later slot**, with that student's agreement, keeping each person's number of leads unchanged. This is the cleanest make-up and the default.
2. **Take an unassigned later slot** if the calendar has slack.
3. **Lead a milestone-studio segment** as a substitute performance if no Mon/Wed slot can be recovered, graded on the same rubric adapted to the studio context.

Document the arrangement so each student's assigned lectures stay correct in the slot assignment posted on the course platform through the end of the semester.

No preparation received: the escalation ladder

Distinct from absence: the lead is present but has not submitted a usable template. Handle it on a fixed ladder so it is predictable and fair.

- **Two days out, no template**: send a reminder that the template is due and that the slot cannot run on the fixed format without it. Note that a missing template affects the preparation portion of the SRL grade even if the session is later led.
- **One day out, still nothing**: confirm directly whether the lead intends to lead. If yes, require at minimum the puzzle, the commitment question, and one AI prompt before end of day: the irreducible core of a runnable session. If that does not arrive, treat the slot as unprepared.

- **Day of, no usable preparation:** the **instructor leads the session** from the lecture notebook's SRL Lead Brief, so the room loses nothing. The student's slot is **rescheduled** into a later make-up (see options above), and the **preparation grade is affected**: the SRL rubric's preparation-dependent rows cannot score at the top when no template was submitted, and the make-up slot carries that record.
- **Pattern of missed preparation** (more than one slot): raise it as an academic-engagement conversation, not just a per-slot penalty, since leading is a graded, recurring responsibility across the semester.

A note on genuine emergencies

Illness and real emergencies are not the same as no-shows. When a lead gives advance notice for a documented reason, run the standby path without the grade penalty and reschedule the make-up on the standard terms. The escalation ladder above is for silence and non-preparation, not for students who communicate.

Related files: [srl_prep_template.md](#) (the document that doubles as the standby script), [instructor_intervention_protocol.md](#) (the two-days-out review that catches a missing template early), [srl_rubric.md](#) (the preparation-dependent rows affected when no template is submitted).